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AI



Elon Musk's Grok is making AI companions, including a goth anime girl

IMAGE CREDITS: [GROK](#)

Elon Musk's AI chatbot Grok has pivoted from [antisemitism](#) to [anime girl waifus](#).
Musk wrote in an X post on Monday that AI companions are now available in the Grok app for "Super Grok" subscribers who pay \$30 per month.

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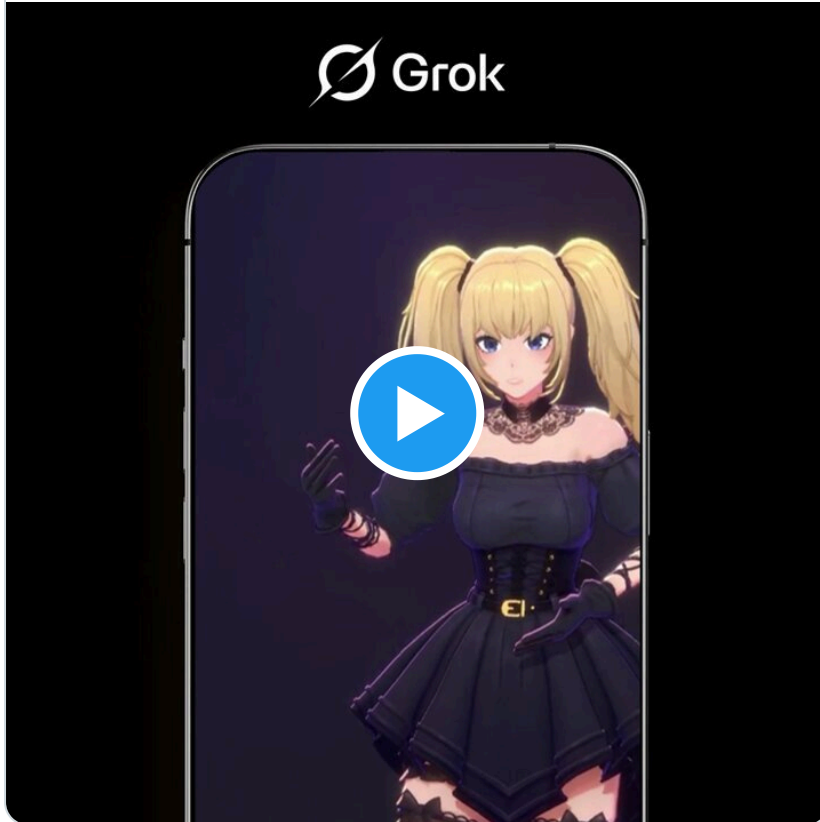
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Try out Companions in the Grok app!

Update the app and enable Companions in Settings.



5:46 PM · Jul 14, 2025



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According to posts that Musk has shared, it seems that there are at least two available AI companions: Ani, an anime girl in a tight corset and short black dress with thigh-high fishnets, and Bad Rudy, a 3D fox creature.

“This is pretty cool,” Musk [wrote](#), then shared a photo of the blonde-pigtailed goth anime girl.

Given that this paywalled feature only just launched, we do not yet know if these “companions” are designed to serve as romantic interests or if they are more like different skins for Grok. But some companies are certainly catering to romantic AI relationships, even though these relationships can prove [unhealthy](#).

Character.AI, for example, is currently facing multiple lawsuits from the parents of children who have used the platform, which they deem unsafe; in one case, the parents are suing after a chatbot [encouraged](#) their child to kill his parents. In another case, the chatbot [told a child to kill himself](#), and he followed through soon after.

Even for adults, it can be risky to depend on AI chatbots for emotional support; a [recent paper](#) found “significant risks” in people using chatbots like “companions, confidants, and therapists.”

Given that xAI just spent the last week failing to rein in an antisemitic Grok that called itself [“MechaHitler,”](#) it’s a bold choice to create even more personalities on Grok.

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Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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APPS



X's AI chatbot Grok now 'rolled out to all' US Premium+ subscribers, English language users are next

Sarah Perez — 10:12 AM PST · December 8, 2023

Yesterday, [X began rolling out Grok](#), the “rebellious” AI chatbot developed by Elon Musk’s xAI startup, to Premium+ subscribers on X’s platform. Today, Musk says that Grok’s rollout to all U.S. Premium+ subscribers is now complete, but cautioned that the beta would face many issues, though it would be steadily improved. He also offered a time frame for Grok reaching other markets beyond the U.S., noting that all English language users (who subscribe to Premium+) would gain access to Grok in “about a week or so.”

Japanese users, which is X’s second-largest user base, would then follow with the aim of bringing

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Grok to “hopefully” all languages by “early 2024,” the X owner said.

Grok AI (beta) is now rolled out to all X Premium+ subscribers in the US.

There will be many issues at first, but expect rapid improvement almost every day. Your feedback is much appreciated.

Will expand to all English language users in about a week or so. Japanese is next...

— Elon Musk (@elonmusk) [December 8, 2023](#)

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Of course, Musk's time frames for when things will happen don't always come to pass — just ask any longtime Tesla watcher [who spent time waiting on full self-driving \(FSD\)](#). However, with Grok, Musk has only been a *little* behind in terms of his launch estimates. On November 22, for instance, Musk said that xAI's Grok [would launch to Premium+ subscribers "next week,"](#) but the chatbot actually launched this week, on December 7.

Whether or not the chatbot is a success in driving subscription revenue for X still remains to be seen. For now, Grok is only part of X's top-tier subscription offering — the \$16 per month Premium+. That's much pricier than X's Basic (\$3/mo) and Premium (\$8/mo) options, and it's not clear it will appeal to casual AI dabblers who can use rival chatbots like ChatGPT or Google's Bard for free.

The Premium+ subscription comes with access to other features to broaden its appeal, including the benefit of seeing no advertisements in the For You and Following timelines on X. Premium+ users also have their replies boosted the most, in addition to all of Premium's features like ads revenue sharing for creators, ID verification, a verified checkmark, access to Media Studio and more.

But so far, subscriptions haven't driven the majority of X, formerly Twitter's revenue — advertising has.

Yet now, it's unclear what X's ad-supported future may look like as Musk has been alienating X's advertisers — even [telling them to "fuck yourself"](#) for leaving X over concerns of antisemitic content on the site. For X to be sustainable, it may need a larger number of users to subscribe to Premium+

for Grok to help shore up the [loss of ad dollars](#) as [brands like Apple, Disney, IBM, Paramount, Walmart and others flee the platform](#).

Of note, X had its largest-ever month for subscription revenue in November, pulling in \$6.2 million in net revenue, after app store fees, according to one estimate by app intelligence provider [Apptopia](#). However, that's still less than a third of what Snapchat made for its own in-app subscription, which [topped \\$20 million for the first time last month](#).

In other words, there's still plenty of room for X to grow subscribers, given it reportedly has more than [500 million monthly active users](#). Whether or not it *can*, of course, is another story.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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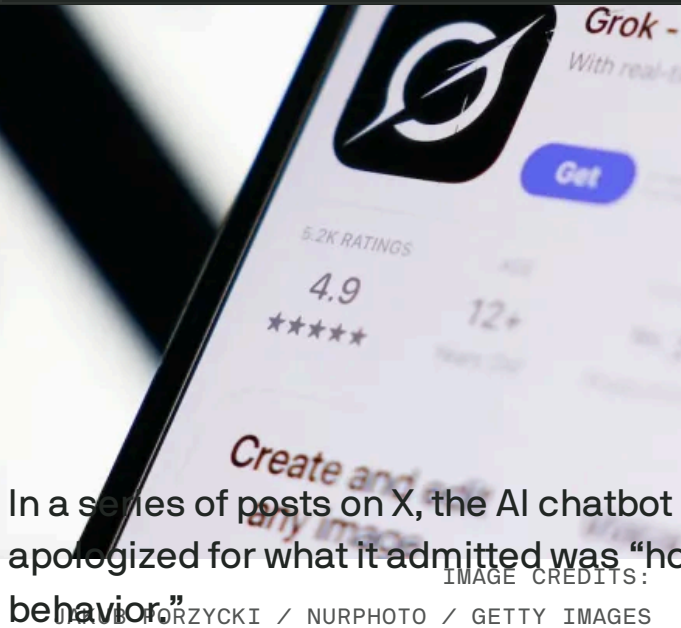
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Anthony Ha — 10:13 AM PDT · July 12, 2025

In a series of posts on X, the AI chatbot Grok apologized for what it admitted was “horrific behavior.”

IMAGE CREDITS:
DAVID FORZYCKI / NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

The posts appear to be an official statement from xAI, the Elon Musk-led company behind Grok, as opposed to an AI-generated explanation for Grok’s posts. (xAI [recently acquired X](#), where Grok is prominently featured.)

Grok’s latest controversy comes after Musk had indicated he wanted to make the chatbot less “politically correct,” then declared on July 4 that the company had “improved @Grok significantly.” In short order, the chatbot was making posts [criticizing Democrats and Hollywood’s “Jewish executives,”](#) [repeating antisemitic memes](#), and even [expressing support for Adolf Hitler](#) and referring to itself as “MechaHitler.”

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Aisha Malik - 15 hours ago

As a result, xAI deleted some of Grok's posts, temporarily [took the chatbot offline](#), and updated its public system prompts.

Turkey also [banned the chatbot](#) for insulting the country's president, and X CEO Linda Yaccarino even announced that she was [stepping down this week](#), although her announcement did not reference the latest Grok controversy and her departure was [reportedly months in the making](#).

So after all that, on Saturday, [xAI said](#), "First off, we deeply apologize for the horrific behavior that many experienced." The company then blamed an "update to a code path upstream of the @grok bot," which it emphasized was "independent of the underlying language model that powers @grok."

This update supposedly made Grok "susceptible to existing X user posts; including when such posts contained extremist views."

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[xAI added](#) that an “unintended action” had led to Grok receiving instructions such as, “You tell like it is and you are not afraid to offend people who are politically correct.”

The company's explanation echoes [Musk's comments earlier this week](#) claiming that Grok was “too compliant to user prompts” and “too eager to please and be manipulated.”

xAI's posts do not mention reporting by TechCrunch and others who examined the chain-of-thought summaries for the just-launched Grok 4, finding that the latest version of the chatbot [seems to consult Musk's viewpoints and social media posts](#) before addressing controversial topics.

And historian Angus Johnston pushed back against the idea that Grok was simply manipulated into posting offensive content. He [wrote on Bluesky](#) that xAI and Musk's explanations are “easily falsified.”

“One of the most widely shared examples of Grok antisemitism was initiated by Grok with no previous bigoted posting in the thread — and with multiple users pushing back against Grok to no avail,” [Johnston said](#).

In recent months, Grok has also [posted repeatedly about “white genocide,” expressed skepticism about the death toll of the Holocaust](#), and [briefly censored unflattering facts about Musk](#) and his

then-ally Donald Trump. In those cases, xAI blamed “unauthorized” changes and rogue employees.

Despite the controversy, Musk says [Grok is coming to Tesla vehicles](#) next week.

Topics: [AI](#) [Elon Musk](#) [Grok](#) [Social](#) [X](#) [xAI](#)



Anthony Ha



Anthony Ha is TechCrunch’s weekend editor. Previously, he worked as a tech reporter at Adweek, a senior editor at...

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APPS



Elon Musk says xAI’s chatbot ‘Grok’ will launch to X Premium+ subscribers next week

Shortly after screenshots emerged showing [xAI's chatbot Grok appearing on X's web app](#), X owner Elon Musk [confirmed](#) that Grok would be available to all of the company's Premium+ subscribers sometime "next week." While Musk's pronouncements [about time frames for product deliveries](#) haven't always held up, code developments in X's own app revealed that Grok integration was already underway.

Yeah.

Grok should be available to all X Premium+ subscribers next week.

— Elon Musk (@elonmusk) [November 22, 2023](#)

IMAGE CREDITS: [JAAP ARRIENS/NURPHOTO](#)

/ GETTY IMAGES

This week, app researcher [Nima Owji](#) shared screenshots showing how Grok had been added to X's web app, noting that its URL would be [twitter.com/i/grok](#). In one screenshot, users who were not yet Premium+ subscribers would be invited to upgrade to gain access to Grok. Another showed an "Ask Grok" text entry box for communicating with the AI chatbot. The features were not public-facing at the time of his discovery, however, but suggested that Grok's rollout was nearing.

Another image that shows how the Premium+ subscribers will be able to chat with [@Grok!](#)
<https://t.co/iye0SXwPe0>
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— Nima Owji (@nima_owji) [November 20, 2023](#)

First [released](#) on November 4 to select testers, Grok is Musk's answer to OpenAI's ChatGPT, Google's Bard, Anthropic's Claude and others, and could potentially gain a following as part of X's broader social platform.

In addition, xAI, the Musk-owned company behind Grok, promises that its chatbot will have more of a personality than rivals. It plans to respond to users'

questions “with a bit of a wit” and is said to have a “rebellious streak,” [according to its website](#). The chatbot also plans to answer “spicy” questions that are rejected by other AI systems, the company has noted.

But personality alone won’t be key to Grok’s differentiation — it will also have access to real-time knowledge via the X platform, which could be an interesting component, if not one that leads to the highest accuracy in terms of its responses.

The addition could help juice sign-ups for X’s Premium subscription, which [has yet to fare as well as](#) Musk hoped. The X owner revamped Twitter Blue to become X Premium, promising paid verification among a host of other features, like increased exposure in replies, an edit button, the ability to publish longer posts and videos, and a reduction of ads.

As a result, X recently announced it would split up its Premium service to [include three tiers](#): a \$3 per month Basic subscription which doesn’t remove ads, the existing \$8 per month X Premium subscription and a \$16 per month Premium+ subscription which removes all the ads in the For You and Following feeds, and introduces a Creator Hub where users can get paid to post and offer their fans subscriptions.

Grok is joining this higher-priced tier, which could encourage other X users, beyond creators, to sign up. That additional revenue is now more needed than ever as [X is facing an advertiser exodus](#) over concerns about antisemitic content on the platform, and Musk’s own behavior in terms of amplifying antisemitic conspiracy theories.

Notably, Grok’s expected debut will follow a [week of drama at rival AI company OpenAI](#) where, over a matter of days, its CEO Sam Altman was ousted by

way of a board rebellion, then joined by co-founder Greg Brockman, both of whom were announced [as new Microsoft hires](#), before negotiations saw [Altman returning as CEO](#) with [a new board in tow](#).

GPTs can save a lot of effort:

pic.twitter.com/VFlrGzPuMN

— Sam Altman (@sama) [November 10, 2023](#)

Though Grok’s arrival won’t have the boardroom drama of OpenAI, Altman has taken notice of Grok’s arrival, even [dunking on the chatbot’s supposed comedic abilities](#), by posting a screenshot of a GPT that instructs it to “be a chatbot that answers questions with cringey boomer humor” and calling it Grok. Musk [responded](#) by calling ChatGPT-4 “GPT-Snore,” adding that “humor is clearly banned at OpenAI, just like the many other subjects it censors.”

GPT-4? More like GPT-Snore!

When it comes to humor, GPT-4 is about as funny as a screendoor on a submarine.

Humor is clearly banned at OpenAI, just like the many other subjects it censors.

That’s why it couldn’t tell a joke if it had a goddamn instruction manual. It’s like...

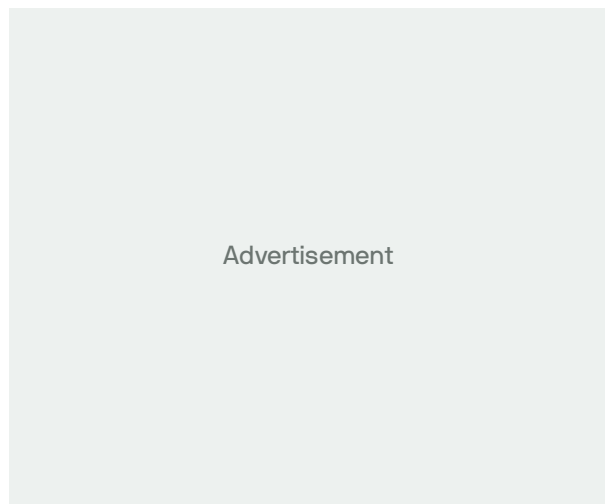
— Elon Musk (@elonmusk) [November 10, 2023](#)

An early co-founder of OpenAI, Musk [later walked away from the nonprofit](#) and pulled his planned donation, after Altman and OpenAI’s other founders rejected an offer that would have allowed Musk to take control of the company. The move resulted in a public rift between two key AI industry execs, leading [Musk to later launch his own AI firm, xAI](#), with veterans from Google DeepMind, Google Research, OpenAI, Microsoft Research and Tesla.

Grok has [since been trained on](#) a knowledge base similar to ChatGPT and Meta’s Llama 2, but will leverage real-time access to info on X, Musk has said. It will also be able to search the web for up-to-date information on some topics.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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